FREE GUIDE

How to Progress Dragon Squat

Multi-creator synthesis. Real intermediate progressions. Follow the journey every Wednesday on @undeniablenick.

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THE GOAL

What We're Building

A clean, unloaded Dragon Squat both sides. Full range of motion. No support. No kettlebell. Just bodyweight.

The non-working leg starts behind your standing leg in a curtsy position, foot off the ground. As you drop into a deep single-leg squat, that leg sweeps around the front and ends up extended straight out, still hovering above the floor. Hip below knee. Spine long. Stand back up under control. Both sides. The "dragon's tail" name comes from the way the leg coils through the movement.

Most people can't do this. Building it puts you in different company.

PREREQUISITES

Don't Skip This

Dragon Squat sits on top of two single-leg patterns and two flexibility tests. Without these, you'll either hurt yourself or stall.

✓ **Pistol Squat: 5 clean reps each side.** Standing on one leg, the other extended straight out, hip below knee, leg parallel to floor throughout.

✓ **Shrimp Squat: 5 clean reps each side.** Hold the ankle of one leg behind you, drop until the knee touches the ground behind your heel.

✓ **Full ROM Cossack squat both sides.** Hip mobility floor.

✓ **Full ATG split squat both sides.** Knee resilience under depth.

✓ **Passive sit test.** Can you sit in the Dragon Squat bottom position passively (knee tucked behind, opposite leg extended)? If not, hip mobility is your gate.

✓ **Active hip adduction test.** From the passive sit, can you actively lift the extended leg off the floor using the inside thigh of the standing leg? This isolates the strength most people don't have.

PICK YOUR PATH BASED ON WHAT YOU PASSED

· **Failed Pistol or Shrimp.** Build those first. 8 to 12 weeks until 5 clean reps each side. Then come back.

· **Failed the passive sit or active lift only.** Start at Phase 1. Floor-based work builds the mobility AND adduction strength simultaneously. The fastest path for true beginners.

· **Passed everything.** Skip to Phase 3. Floor work isn't necessary at your level. Train the actual standing pattern.

· **Passed most, stuck on one specific area.** Use the Universal Regressions menu (later) to drill that gap, then enter at the right phase.

8 TO 10 MINUTES EVERY DAY

Daily Mobility Prep

UNDENIABLE NICK

Run this every day. Training day or not. Dragon Squat is mobility-bound. Strength alone won't unlock it. Daily exposure to deep ranges is what builds the skill.

Deep Squat Hold: 60 seconds, heels down

Cossack Squat (full ROM): 6 reps / side, slow

Hip 90/90 Transitions: 5 reps / side

Wall Tibialis Raises: 20 reps

Couch Stretch (hip flexor): 60 seconds / side

Pistol Squat with Leg Raise: 5 reps / side (in deep pistol bottom, lift the non-working leg)

Active Side-Leg Lifts: 10 reps / side, slow

ATG Split Squat (deep hold): 30 seconds / side

WHY THESE SPECIFIC MOVES

Cossack and ATG split squat give you the foundational depth.
Hip 90/90 trains the external rotation that holds the rear leg up.
Tib raises build the ankle dorsiflexion that any deep squat requires.
Couch stretch opens the rear-leg hip flexor for the leg-back position.
Side-leg lifts directly train the adductor and abductor that fail at depth.

THE HONEST MINIMUM

If you only do 4 of these, do Cossack, Hip 90/90, Couch Stretch, and Side-Leg Lifts. Those four cover 80% of the mobility work that gates Dragon Squat. The other three accelerate it.

THE PATH

How the Progression Works

Five phases. Phases 1 and 2 are floor-based (no standing) and exist for true beginners who failed the passive sit or active lift test. Phases 3 to 5 are the standing pattern. **Where you start depends on the path you picked from the prerequisite test.**

PHASE 1 · DRAGON TAIL LIFT (Path A: floor-based entry)

Lay on your forearm, side-lying. Lift the top leg with toes pointing laterally. Progress: post up onto the long arm with torso vertical. Lift the foot as high as you can. Floor-based, no squat yet. This is where the lateral hip strength gets built without a balance demand.

PHASE 2 · DRAGON TAIL SQUAT (Path A continues)

From the tail-lift, lift hip and foot off the floor (sequentially first, eventually together) and land back into the squat with care. Builds outer hip mobility on the bending leg and inner hip on the straight leg together. This phase is the gate for true beginners. Live in it.

PHASE 3 · BABY DRAGON (Path B starts here if you passed all prereqs)

Standing. Knee kisses the floor to the side of the standing leg (not behind). Keep range of motion small at first. Build to: knee in line with the pinky toe AND elbow touching the floor in the same moment.

PHASE 4 · ASSISTED DRAGON

Baby Dragon, then place the hand down and elongate the tail (extend the leg further from behind to in front). Use the hand to fulfill the opening. Each session, use the hand less and less.

PHASE 5 · FULL DRAGON SQUAT

No assistance. Clean rotation, both sides, deep ROM. **Form cues:** connect armpit of working leg to working knee. Pressure on the INSIDE edge of the standing foot. Inner thigh squeezes up like holding a ball. Drive up through the quad with torso vertical, never through the hips. Knee past toes is normal and safe at this depth.

THE CUE THAT MATTERS MOST

Don't get lazy with the foot. Keep it as high as you can hold it through every rep, every phase. The lift of the tail is what separates a Dragon Squat from a sloppy collapse.

THE MAP

5 Phases · 4 to 6 Months

Don't rush phases. Each one builds the strength and mobility for the next. If a phase feels like it's taking longer than expected, it is. That's fine.

Phase 1 **Wks 1-3**	Dragon Tail Lift. Floor-based. Side-lying with leg lifted, then post-up onto long arm. Builds the lateral hip lift before any squatting.
Phase 2 **Wks 4-7**	Dragon Tail Squat. Still floor-based. Lift hip and foot off the floor, land back into the squat. Conditioning for outer + inner hip together.
Phase 3 **Wks 8-12**	Baby Dragon (Rotational Shrimp). Standing. Knee kisses the floor to the side of the standing leg. Build to knee + elbow on floor.
Phase 4 **Wks 13-17**	Assisted Dragon. Hand down to elongate the tail. Use the hand less each session until you don't need it.
Phase 5 **Wks 18+**	Full Dragon Squat. No assistance. Use a yoga block or decking edge if needed. THE GOAL.

WHERE MOST PEOPLE GET STUCK

Hip adduction strength to keep the floating leg HOVERING. Most often this fails in Phase 2 (Tail Squat). Don't rush past it. And remember: balance fails before muscular strength does. If you feel unsteady, that's a balance gap, not a strength gap. Train in the position, not around it.

TWO PRINCIPLES TO TRAIN BY

Lead with the weaker side. Single-leg work has a measurable cross-effect: train the weak side hard and the strong side comes along for the ride. Spend roughly 60 percent of your session work on whichever side you're worse on. Both sides equal is the only acceptable endpoint.

Knees past toes is normal at depth. Restricting knee travel just forces more torque into the hip. Dragon Squat requires deep knee flexion, period. Stop fighting it. Build ankle mobility (tib raises) so your knee can travel where it needs to and the weight stays where it should.

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>
> Your body doesn't change because you did the prescribed reps. It changes because you gave it a reason to.
>
> NICK CHIASSON

Intermediate Progressions

Most people stall between phases because the gap is too big. These bridges fill each gap. Run them 2 to 3 times per week, 3 working sets, until you can clear 3 sets of 6 clean reps both sides at the same tempo. Then move up.

BRIDGE 1 · PHASE 1 TO PHASE 2

· **Kneeling rear-leg lift hold** — 3 to 5 sec hold, 3×5/side
· **Half-kneeling to standing** (no rear lift) — 3×6/side, 3s up
· **Kneeling-to-half-squat partial ROM** — 3×6/side, slow eccentric
· **Reverse Nordic curl partial ROM** — 3×5 to 8, lean only as far as control allows

BRIDGE 2 · PHASE 2 TO PHASE 3 (the biggest gap)

Easiest to hardest. Run the first three for 2 to 3 weeks before introducing the rest:
· **Box-assisted Baby Dragon** (high box, ~18-20") — 3×5/side, 3s eccentric
· **Reduced-ROM shrimp squat** to yoga blocks, drop 1 to 2" per week — 3×6/side
· **Counterbalance shrimp squat** (5 to 10 lb plate forward) — 3×5/side, 2-up/2-down
· **Curtsy shrimp squat** (rear foot crosses behind) — 3×4/side
· **Eccentric-only Baby Dragon** (5s descent, hand-assist up) — 3×4/side
· **Reverse Nordic curl, full ROM** — 3×8 to 12, arms overhead to progress
· **Bulgarian split squat, deep ROM** (rear foot ~6" elevation) — 3×10/side

BRIDGE 3 · PHASE 3 TO PHASE 4

· **Cossack squat (full ROM)** — 3×6/side, daily mobility OK
· **Pistol squat to box**, lower box every 1 to 2 weeks — 3×5/side
· **Hand-guided Dragon** (hand cues the rear-leg path) — 3×3/side
· **Limited-range Dragon eccentric** — descend halfway, hold 3 to 10s, return — 3×3/side

BRIDGE 4 · PHASE 4 TO PHASE 5

· **Band-assisted Dragon**, hand off the band on ascent — 3×3/side
· **Full eccentric Dragon**, palm-push to stand — 3×3/side, 4-5s descent
· **Counterbalance full Dragon** (5 to 10 lb plate forward) — 3×3/side
· **Pause-rep Dragon** (2s pause at bottom, no assist) — 2-3×2/side

HOW TO KNOW WHEN YOU'RE READY TO MOVE UP

The gate: 3 sets of 6 clean reps both sides at the same tempo. Single-side dominance is the #1 regression signal. Train the weak side first, match the strong side's volume. Don't move up until the weaker side hits the gate. Realistic timeline: Phase 2 to 3 alone is 4 to 8 weeks. Full Phase 1 to 5 is 6 to 12 months. Trust the process.

DON'T GET HURT

Safety

DON'T

- ✕ Force depth.
- ✕ Train through sharp knee or hip pain.
- ✕ Lock the rear leg out fully if your abductor cramps.
- ✕ Skip mobility prep.
- ✕ Drop the box height before you've earned it.

DO

- ✓ Slow the descent. Four seconds down.
- ✓ Let the front knee track past the toes.
- ✓ Use a wall or pole for balance early on.
- ✓ Train both sides equally.
- ✓ Film yourself. Watch your own reps.

WHAT THIS GUIDE DOESN'T COVER

Individual scaling for your body. Form review on YOUR rep. Modifications for hip impingement, knee history, or ankle limitations. The deeper system. That's coaching territory, not free-guide territory.

Follow the Journey

Every Wednesday on Instagram and TikTok. Drills, fails, depth gains. Real-time progression to a clean Dragon Squat both sides. Tag **@undeniablenick** when you film yourself doing the work.

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